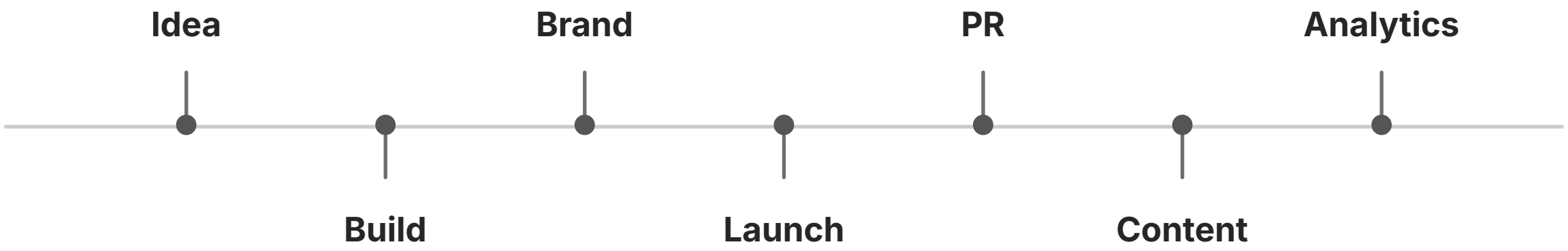
FOUNDER PLAYBOOK

Vibe Coding: From Idea to Launch and Beyond

A structured **7-phase path** for early-stage founders to go from idea to market, build momentum, and keep growing.



PHASE 1

Idea: Find Something Worth Building

Before writing a single line of code, validate that the problem is real and the market exists. Use AI research tools and community signals to narrow in on a wedge worth pursuing.

Your Research Stack

ChatGPT & Claude

Brainstorm problems, explore markets, and stress-test assumptions fast.

Perplexity

AI-powered search with cited sources for deeper market research.

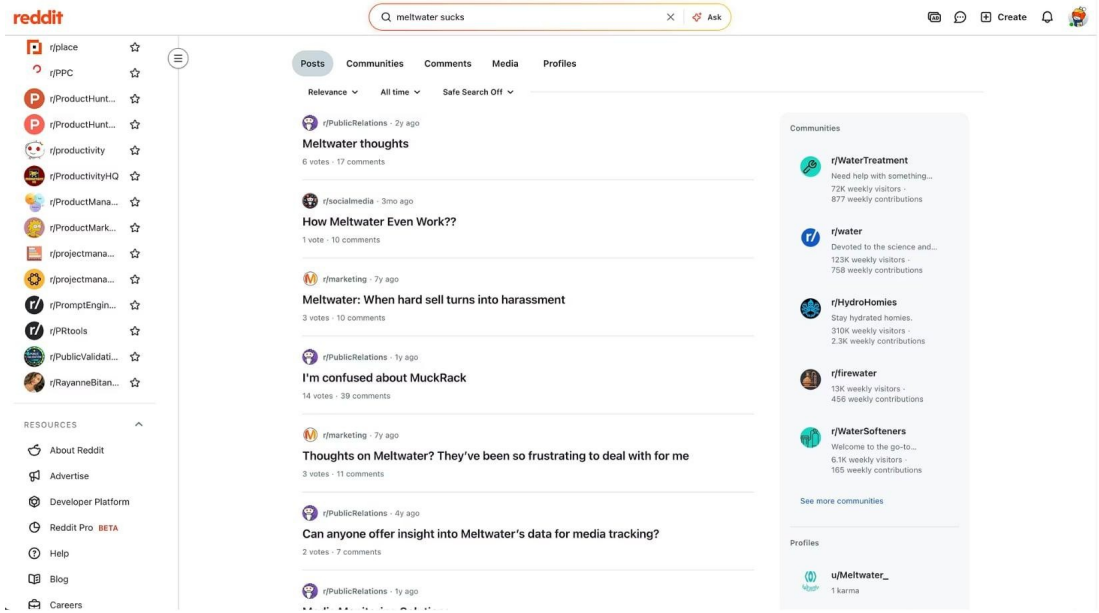
Reddit & X

Listen to real conversations — find pain points people are already complaining about.

Founder tip: The best ideas often hide in plain sight — in forum rants, support tickets, and "there has to be a better way" moments.

PHASE 1

Idea Example: Reddit Subreddits



- **Problems:** Search for existing apps or generic phrases describing the problem e.g. Reddit, Facebook etc
- **Research:** Read the comments, ask questions via replies
- **Lists:** Make a list of all the pain points and issues regarding potential solutions
- **Idea(s):** Use AI plus your own intuition to narrow down to the idea

PHASE 2

Build: Ship Your MVP

Speed is your unfair advantage. Use modern AI-assisted dev tools to go from zero to shipped in days, not months. Focus on the core loop; everything else is secondary.

AI Vibe Code Platforms

Cursor, Lovable, v0, Bolt — Generate, edit, and scaffold code with AI at your side.

Dev Environments

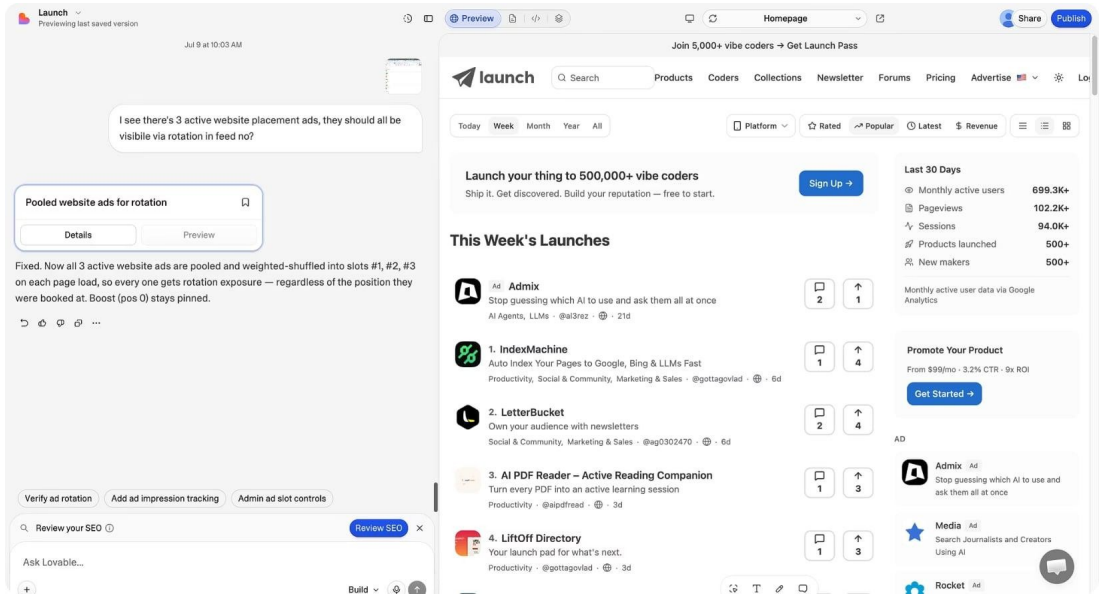
Codex, GitHub — Spin up projects instantly and collaborate with version control from day one.

Backend & Payments

Supabase, Stripe — Plug in auth, databases, and payments without reinventing the wheel.

PHASE 2

Build Example: Lovable .com



- **Vibe Coding Platform:** Sign up to Lovable, great for MVPS (I built my multiple MVP apps using it)
- **Backend:** Sign up to Supabase and Github, link to your Lovable project
- **Payments:** Add Stripe to accept payments
- **Advanced:** Use more advanced AI coding environments when you're ready i.e Codex

PHASE 3

Brand: Turn MVP into a Trusted Product

Great products fail without a great story. Rocket gives founders the brand strategy, positioning, and launch assets to show up like a company not a side project.

Brand consists of:

Brand Strategy & Positioning

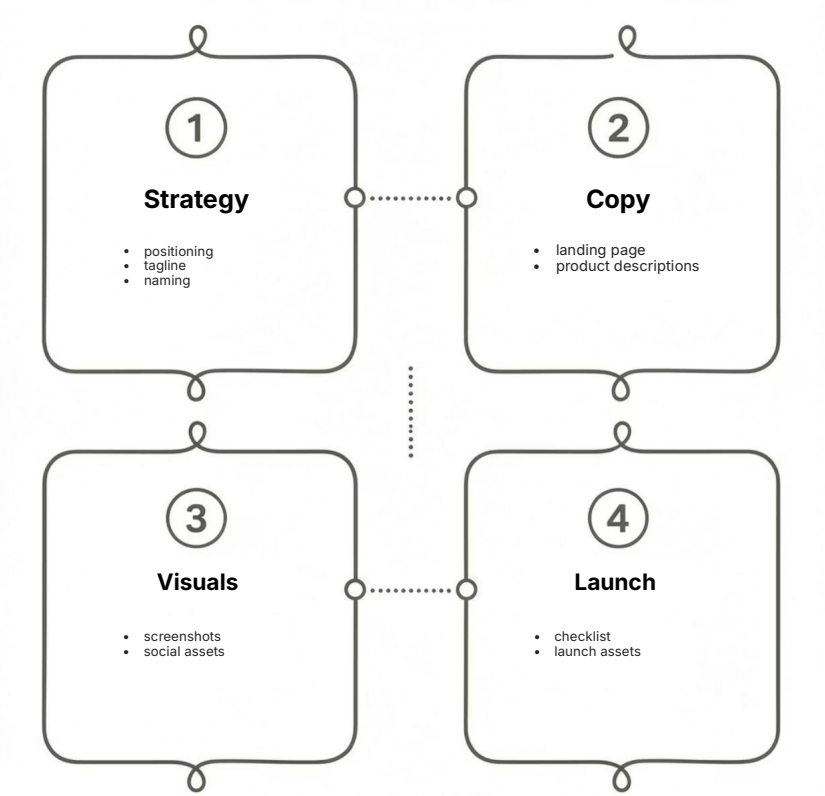
Define who you are, who you serve, and why you win.

Tagline, Naming & Copy

Craft the words that make people remember you.

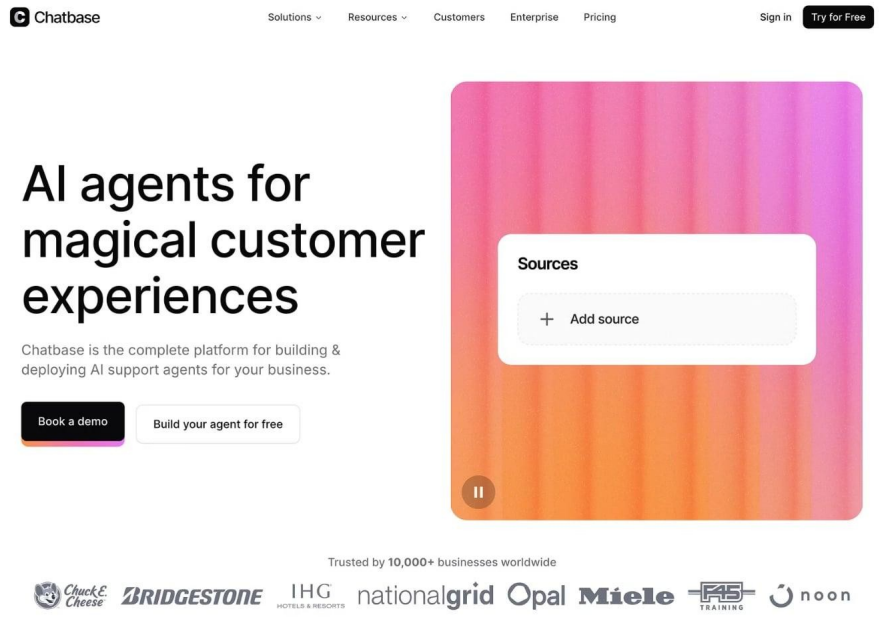
Landing Page & Launch Assets

Screenshots, social assets, product descriptions, and a full launch checklist.



PHASE 3

Brand Example: Chatbase Homepage



- **Brand positioning:** e.g. Chatbase is the brand for AI chat agents
- **Tagline:** e.g. AI agents for magical customer experiences'
- **Key messaging:** e.g. 'Chatbase is the complete platform for building & deploying AI support agents for your business'
- **Assets:** Launch assets created e.g hero graphics, customer logos etc

PHASE 4

Launch: Get Discovered

Launch day is not luck; it's a system. Build your presence across the right platforms, optimize for discovery, and activate communities before you hit publish.

Landing Page

Your product's main funnel — optimized for conversion and first impressions.

SEO & Discovery

Rank for the right keywords and get found by the right people.

Community Platforms

Product Hunt, Hacker News, Reddit, Indie Hackers — activate each with a tailored strategy.

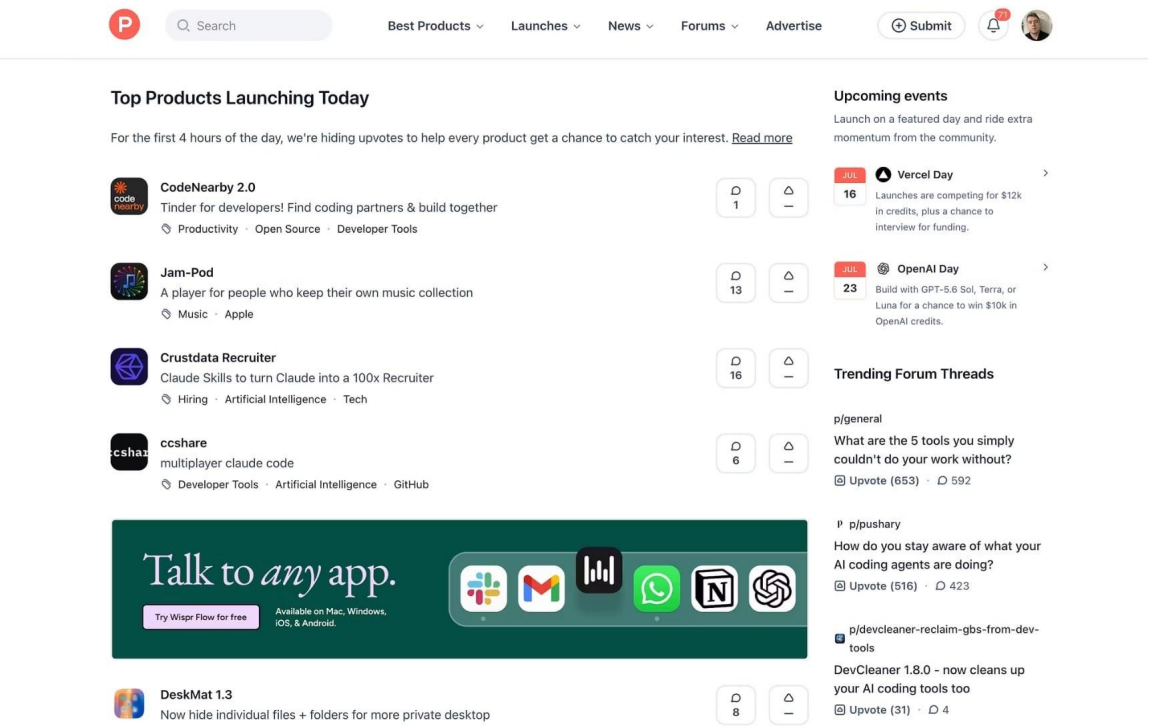
Founder Profile

Your story is a differentiator. Build a founder profile that earns trust and drives clicks.

PHASE 4

Launch Example: Product Hunt (Obviously)

Launch day is not luck; it's a system. Build your presence across the right platforms, optimize for discovery, and activate communities before you hit publish.



- **Platforms launched on:**
  - Product Hunt
  - Hacker News
  - Reddit subreddits (e.g., /r/saas, /r/startups)
  - Twitter/X
  - LinkedIn
- **Community activation:**
  - Early adopter engagement
  - Pre-launch outreach to influencers/beta users
  - Engagement on launch day posts
- **Initial traction:**
  - Sign-ups/users acquired
  - Website traffic
  - Mentions/shares
- **Launch day results:**
  - Key metrics achieved
  - Learnings and next steps

PHASE 5

PR: Get People Talking

Press doesn't happen by accident. Build relationships with journalists, creators, and influencers then run structured outreach campaigns that earn coverage and build credibility.

Media Strategy

1

Journalists

Identify and pitch reporters who cover your space.

2

Creators & Influencers

Partner with voices your audience already trusts.

3

Outreach & Email Templates

Personalized, scalable outreach that gets replies.

4

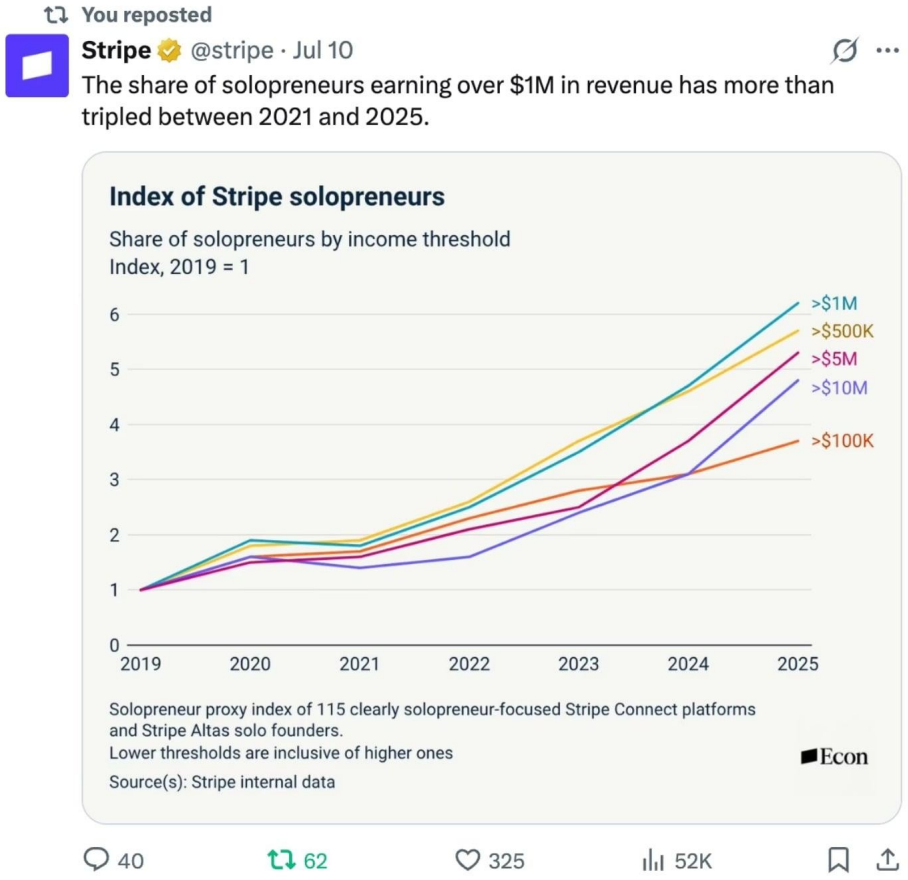
Campaigns

Coordinate press drops with launch timing for maximum impact.

Key insight: A single well-placed media mention can outperform weeks of paid ads. Build the relationships early.

PHASE 5

PR Example: Stripe Internal Data



- **Identify Data:** Every startup produces data, access yours
- **Turn Data Into Content:** Create engaging content from the data e.g Tweets, infographics, videos etc
- **Distribute:** Distribute the content on your personal and brand accounts, experiment across different social media channels, email and wherever works best for your startup

PHASE 6

Content: Stay Visible

Launch day is just the beginning. A consistent content engine keeps your product top of mind, builds audience trust, and compounds over time all the way to your next launch.

Repurpose

Turn one piece of content into posts, threads, reels, and newsletters.

Schedule

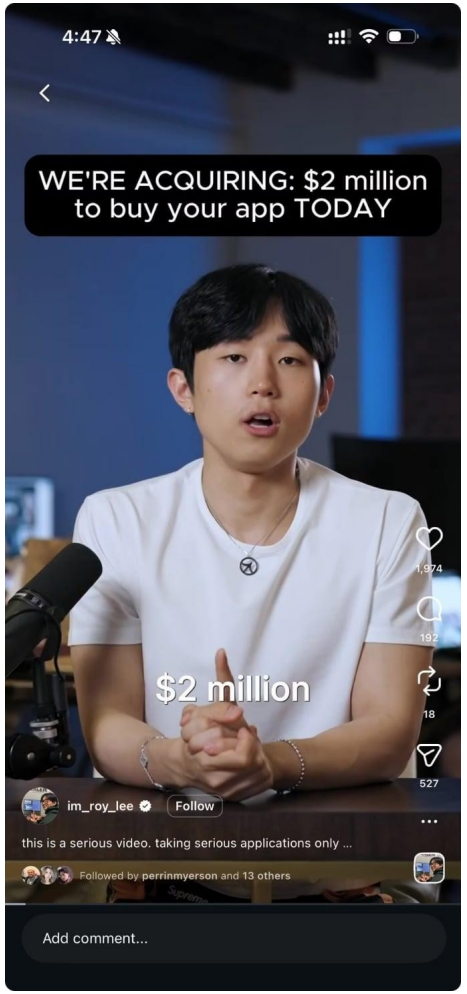
Batch-create and schedule posts so consistency never depends on motivation.

Distribute

Publish across X, LinkedIn, Threads, Instagram, and TikTok — meet your audience where they are.

PHASE 6

Content Example: Cluely Founder Roy Lee



- **Content Pillars:** Design content pillars to define your main topics and themes, Cluely is focused on startups, ragebait and founders
- **Posting Frequency:** Develop a posting frequency to specify how often you publish content across channels whether thats X, Instagram, TikTok, YouTube etc
- **Best Content:** Identify top performing content then double down on content that outperforms and put paid ads behind it if possible
- **Content Growth:** Drive audience growth by outlining content's role in reaching and engaging new users and expand from there

PHASE 7

Analytics: Understand What Worked

Data closes the loop. Use analytics to see what drove traffic, what converted, and what to double down on then feed those insights directly into your next build cycle.

Analytics Stack

GA4

Traffic sources, user behavior, and conversion funnels.

PostHog

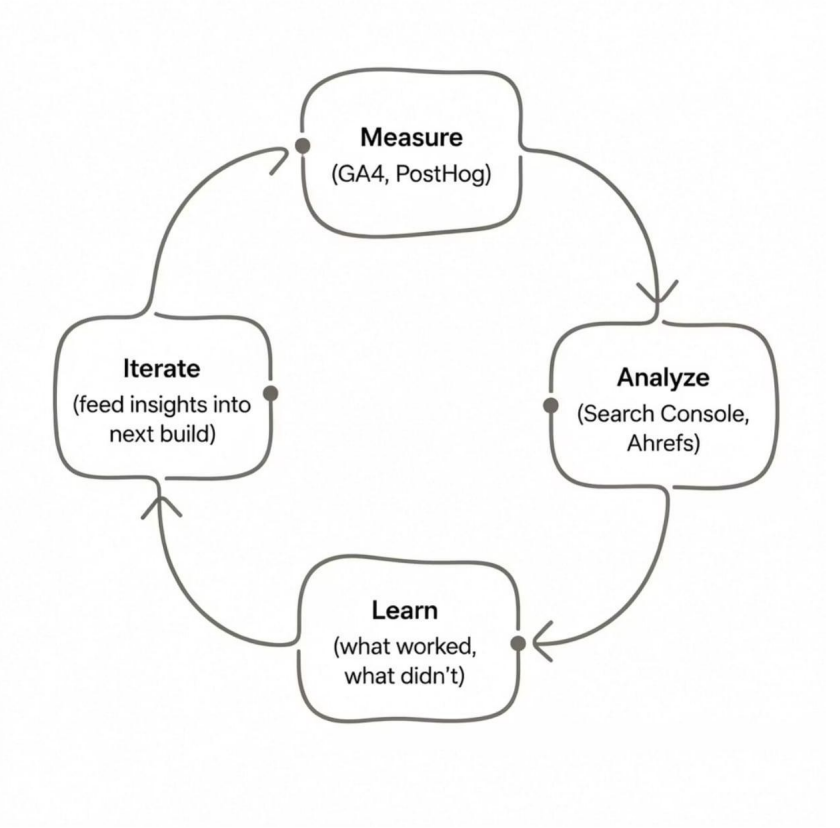
Product analytics and feature usage tracking.

Google Search Console

Search performance and indexing insights.

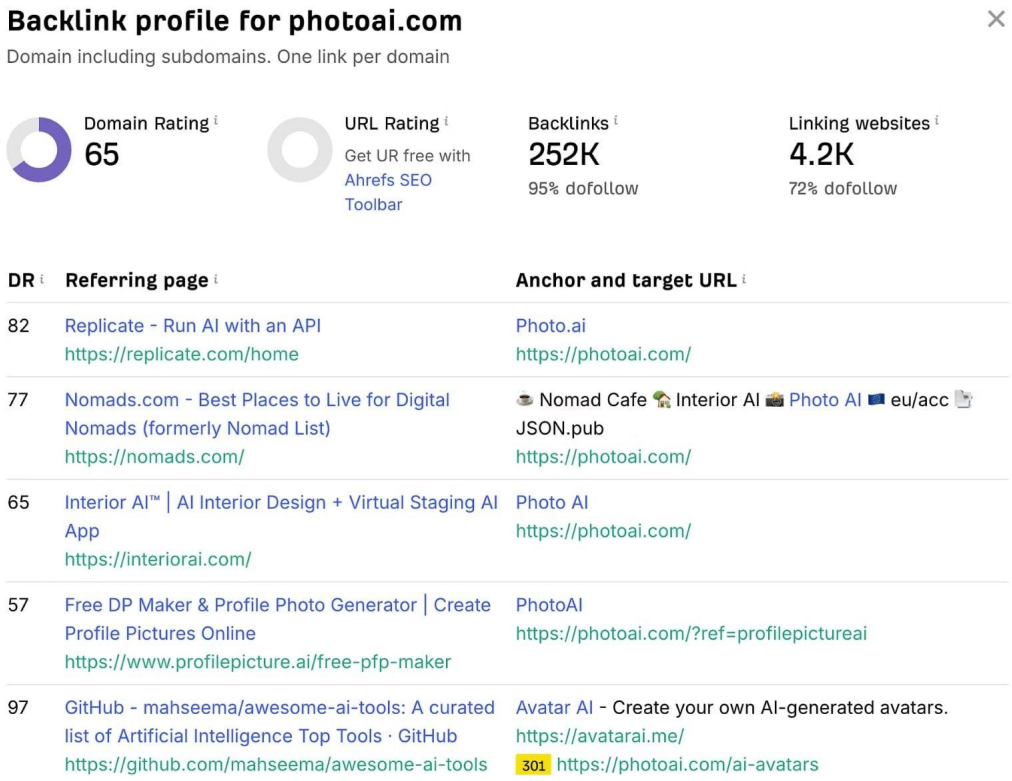
Ahrefs & Plausible

SEO intelligence and privacy-friendly web analytics.



PHASE 7

Analytics Example: Ahrefs SEO Data



Backlink profile for photoai.com

Domain including subdomains. One link per domain

Domain Rating	URL Rating	Backlinks	Linking websites
65	Get UR free with Ahrefs SEO Toolbar	252K 95% dofollow	4.2K 72% dofollow

DR	Referring page	Anchor and target URL
82	Replicate - Run AI with an API https://replicate.com/home	Photo.ai https://photoai.com/
77	Nomads.com - Best Places to Live for Digital Nomads (formerly Nomad List) https://nomads.com/	☕ Nomad Cafe 🏡 Interior AI 📸 Photo AI 🇪🇺 eu/acc 📄 JSON.pub https://photoai.com/
65	Interior AI™ | AI Interior Design + Virtual Staging AI App https://interiorai.com/	Photo AI https://photoai.com/
57	Free DP Maker & Profile Photo Generator | Create Profile Pictures Online https://www.profilepicture.ai/free-pfp-maker	PhotoAI https://photoai.com/?ref=profilepictureai
97	GitHub - mahseema/awesome-ai-tools: A curated list of Artificial Intelligence Top Tools · GitHub https://github.com/mahseema/awesome-ai-tools	Avatar AI - Create your own AI-generated avatars. https://avatarai.me/ 301 https://photoai.com/ai-avatars

- **Traffic sources:** e.g., Organic Search, Social, Paid
- **Conversion rate:** e.g., 5%, 10% from signup to paid
- **Key learnings:** e.g., X feature drives Y engagement
- **Next iteration focus:** e.g., A/B test pricing, improve onboarding

Summary

Every phase feeds the next. This is the full operating system — from first idea to second launch and beyond. The best founders don't stop at launch; they build the loop.

01

Idea

Validate the problem

02

Build

Ship the MVP

03

Brand

Brand & launch assets

04

Launch

Discovery & community

05

PR

PR & outreach

06

Content

Content distribution

07

Analytics

Measure & learn

08

Keep Building

Iterate with data



Alex MacGregor

I build software, help founders launch & document the process.

X: **@alexmacgregor__**
Instagram: **@alexmacgregor__**
YouTube: **@alexmacgregor**
TikTok: **@alexmacgregor__**
LinkedIn: **alexmacgregor2**